

service at many Indian cricket stadiums and simply assumed things at Headingley would be just as wonderful. But on day one, hopes crashed with a serving of plain rice, mac and cheese, and a sorry-looking vegetable.

At one moment, the Diary began thinking of itself as Charles Dickens' Oliver Twist asking for more. But it soon climbed down from its perch, took things in its stride and admonished itself for having lofty expectations. Food at a stadium is a complimentary service, not a right, said the Diary's mind voice.

But by the end of the Test, the grapevine suggested that even local journalists were aghast at the food arrangements. One senior scribe claimed that those in charge had slashed the catering budget. The Diary was now relieved and decided to up its expectations from Birmingham, the venue for the second Test. "It cannot be as bad as Leeds," said another scribe of the sharp-tongued variety.

Namesakes

Bradford and Leeds are like twin cities, separated by around 10 miles. One of Bradford's most famous sons is England spinner Adil Rashid, and most cricket-loving Asians in the Bradford-Leeds area — especially those of Pakistani origin — are proud of Rashid.

A taxi driver, also named Adil, told the Diary that he had played childhood cricket with Rashid. "His father was very good. He supported him throughout. Without family, nothing is possible," he added. Adil said there could have been three Rashids playing for England, not just one. "Haroon, his brother, was a very good batter. But he went the wrong way," he said.

The Diary was in no mood for controversies and slipped into silent mode. The return taxi from the stadium was driven by one Mohammed Siraj, who, apart from sharing a name with an illustrious Indian bowler, also claimed to be Rashid's neighbour. For a fleeting moment, the Diary had the itch to ask the driver to take it to Rashid's locality. But barging in uninvited is

not really the Diary's style — and that thought died a quick death.

Trial by heat

The Diary has often been condescending towards those from the global West complaining about heat. "Nothing compares to subcontinental heat and we can tolerate temperatures up to 40°C," the Diary had always believed.

The first few days in Leeds and then Birmingham burst that bubble spectacularly.

It couldn't even handle the 30-degree temperature, for it felt far more oppressive than the same reading back home. It felt like that famous boast of Indians saying they were better players of spin bowling.

We all know how that has panned out in recent years.

The fact that most of the United Kingdom doesn't have air-conditioning made it worse for the Diary. The Headingley stadium press area made for a fantastic viewing experience, but it had just a handful of portable table fans for 100-odd people. The Diary was, however, lucky to be seated next to one and thanked its stars daily.

Days four and five in Leeds saw cooler temperatures before Birmingham put the Diary to test again with another sweltering spell. It was then decided to humbly not brag anymore about the Diary's heat-resisting capabilities.



Headingley hustle: Fans walk along narrow St. Michael's Lane leading to Headingley Stadium in Leeds on day one of the first Test between England and India. N. SUDARSHAN